PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #43 · ANXIETY

“I can’t cope if the worst happens.”

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Where it often comes from

People who have been through a real crisis, or who grew up without enough help, often practice the worst in their minds so they will not be surprised. The practice becomes a belief: if the worst arrived, I would not be able to stand it. Anxiety lives in that rehearsal. It spends today’s strength on a day that has not come, and then concludes from the exhaustion that coping is impossible.

What Scripture teaches

God does not ask you to carry a future catastrophe today. He does promise strength, presence, and grace for weakness. “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.” His grace is sufficient, and His power is perfected in weakness. He will not leave you or forsake you. He is a refuge and strength, an ever-present help. These verses are not a claim that the worst will never happen. They are a claim that you will not face it alone, and that strength is given for the day you are in.

> *“I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength”* (Philippians 4:13).

Also see

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged” (Deuteronomy 31:8).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

Common self-statements

- I would fall apart.
- I cannot even think about it.
- Other people could handle it. I could not.
- If I imagine it enough, maybe I will be ready, but I never feel ready.
- God helps strong people. I am not one of them.
- The only safe plan is to make sure the worst never happens.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Living through a disaster that has not happened and grading yourself on it.
- Catastrophizing: Treating the worst case as the case you must solve now.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If I cannot picture myself calm in the worst, I cannot cope at all.
- Discounting the positive: Forgetting the hard days I have already come through.

Challenging questions

- What is the worst I am rehearsing, and is it happening today?

- When have I coped with something hard that I had dreaded?
- Am I asking for strength for a real day, or for a movie in my head?
- What help would I actually have if that day came?
- What does “Christ gives me strength” mean for today, not for every fear?
- What is one present responsibility I can do without solving the worst case?

Truth summary

> I do not have to survive the worst before it comes. God gives strength for the day I am actually in.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

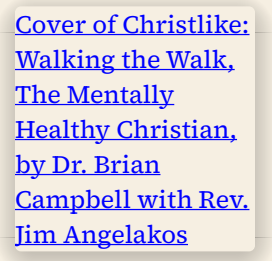
- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Help
- Trust
- God, All Powerful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Weak/Tired
- Trouble/Hardship

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Greater — MercyMe
God's strength is greater than the scene you are rehearsing.

Our God — Chris Tomlin
You are not left to cope with the worst by yourself.

More Than Conquerors — Steven Curtis Chapman
In Christ you are not defined by the fear of being overwhelmed.

Because He Lives — Bill and Gloria Gaither
Because He lives, you can face what actually comes.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't cope if the worst happens."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't cope if the worst happens." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the worst I am rehearsing, and is it happening today?
- ☐ When have I coped with something hard that I had dreaded?
- ☐ Am I asking for strength for a real day, or for a movie in my head?
- ☐ What help would I actually have if that day came?
- ☐ What does "Christ gives me strength" mean for today, not for every fear?
- ☐ What is one present responsibility I can do without solving the worst case?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not have to survive the worst before it comes. God gives strength for the day I am actually in.
- ☐ I do not have to cope with tomorrow's disaster today.
- ☐ Christ gives strength for what is real, not for every scene I invent.
- ☐ God's grace is sufficient in weakness.
- ☐ I have coped with hard days before, with help.
- ☐ Being afraid of the worst is not the same as being unable to face a real day.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:13
  "I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "I couldn't cope" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when a future disaster felt unbearable. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 4:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I do not have to live the worst today. Christ gives me strength for this day.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Park the worst case. Write it on a card, put the card away, and do one task that belongs to today.
- [ ] List survived days. Write three hard things you got through. Note who helped.
- [ ] Ask what help would exist. If the feared event is realistic, name one person and one practical help you would use. Then stop rehearsing.
- [ ] Pray for today's strength only each morning, using Isaiah 41:10.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't cope if the worst happens.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A fear I did not have to live today
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't cope if the worst happens~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I keep trying to survive days that have not come. Give me strength for this one. Remind me that Your grace is enough if a hard day actually arrives. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.